2 – Writing Great Prompts

MLI Rubrics Project – Lesson 2.mp4

Objective

By the end of this lesson, you'll be able to:

- Write clear, challenging prompts that simulate real-world professional workflows
- Ensure that each prompt requires multi-step reasoning, not simple recall
- Avoid common pitfalls that lead to invalid or low-quality prompts

What Is a Prompt?

A **prompt** is the kind of high-level, challenging assignment you'd give to a smart, reliable colleague if you wanted expert help on a complex task. It's the kind of work you wish AI could actually do well today. It's not just a simple question or a fact you could Google; it's a real professional deliverable, like drafting a valuation analysis for a client, preparing a legal memo on a tricky regulatory issue, proposing a market entry strategy for a multinational company, or recommending a diagnosis based on a complicated patient case.

When you write a prompt, you're simulating these real-world challenges — the tasks where, if AI could do them well, it would genuinely make your life easier, save you time, and help you deliver better work. Our job is to push AI to that level of expertise by defining these tasks clearly, with all the context, expectations, and constraints that an expert human would need to succeed.

In this project, a prompt is a carefully written task that asks the AI model to perform a high-level, professional deliverable, similar to what you might ask a skilled senior colleague to produce.

This could look like:

- Finance: Requesting a fairness opinion on a large company's acquisition of a startup. Using intrinsic, extrinsic, and precedent transaction methodologies, and then comparing the average of these valuations to the actual acquisition price.
- Medicine: Creating a differential diagnosis and an immediate mgmt. plan based on the most likely diagnosis for a patient case using diagnostic data and medical literature.
- Law: Drafting a memorandum for an automotive company on the legal differences between due diligence under the CSDDD and the duty of care under the PROTECT USA Act, and the feasibility of simultaneous compliance with Bluebook citations.
- Consulting: Analyze the plant-based milk for a new product launch by determining the market size, growth, and leading segments to recommend the most opportune segment for the a client's new product
- Education: Creating a lesson plan for a specific audience, with targeted objectives

- Insurance: Detecting fraud cues in a narrative, producing coverage-gap reports, or proposing renewal offers for expiring policies
- Sales & Marketing: Forecast sales revenue from a pipeline, segment customer audiences from data, or build a campaign and outline
- Retail & E-commerce: Generate SKU reorder proposals from forecast data, full E2E creation of a brand, monthly store scorecard design

In short, prompts are not just “questions.” They are professional requests that demand expertise, analysis, and structured thinking.

What Makes a Great Prompt?

The top AI labs are hiring you for this work because ***you*** are the expert. **You** know the difference between a task that’s truly demanding in your field – the kind of assignment that would actually challenge a trained professional – versus tasks that just aren’t that impactful, difficult, or meaningful in real-world work.

The labs can’t tell that difference on their own. They need your expertise to define what it really means to perform at a high level in finance, law, medicine, or consulting. That’s why your judgment in crafting these prompts is so valuable – you’re helping set the bar for what expert performance actually looks like.

So here’s what defines a high-quality prompt. A high-quality prompt must:

1. **Require deep reasoning:** The task should not be solvable by surface-level knowledge or a quick web search.

2. **Simulate real workflows and require expertise from a professional in your field:** The prompt should mirror how professionals approach problems in their field, including the need for context analysis, data synthesis, and structured decision-making. And it should require the expertise of someone in your profession in order to properly answer the question.

3. **Have a clear objective:** The prompt should be well-defined so that any seasoned professional expert, with the right resources provided, would know exactly what deliverable is expected, including the required format, length, and any constraints.

4. **Include necessary constraints:** Specify any conditions, limitations, or perspectives the model should adopt.
    - For example, you might specify conditions like:
        i. “Assume a conservative investor profile” or
        ii. “Focus on EU regulatory frameworks” or
        iii. “Include the min, max percent differences as absolute values” or
        iv. “The patient is an 8month old, fully vaccinated, boy with runny nose, mild cough, and congestion x 1 week presents with fever x 2 days and increased fussiness”

        v. “The lease also permits the assignment and sublet of the unit with Tower Properties' consent. The unit is neither rent controlled, nor rent subsidized.”
    - For prompts involving numeral answer or outputs, you should also specify what units should be used (i.e., Present the EBITDA in USD)

5. **Require supporting documents to reach a solution:** Your prompt should require reference to the supporting documents you’ll pair it with, ensuring the model must engage with external files or provided data rather than guessing. Your prompt cannot be answered solely using base model reasoning that could be found in a typical AI model. You need some sort of external documentation or web search in order to complete the task that is being requested.

6. **Have a solution that experts in the field would generally agree on** or that the quality of the answer can be judged by objective criteria: if the answer to the prompt is highly subjective and could change vastly from person to person, then it’s not a great prompt for this project. Instead, there should be a clear basis for what constitutes a correct or superior answer.

What to Avoid When Writing Prompts

Now, let’s talk about what to **avoid** when writing your prompts.

- First – **avoid trivia or recall-based tasks**. For example, don’t write a prompt that asks, “What year did the Financial Crisis start?” That’s just a fact. The model can easily answer that by memory or a quick search – there’s no reasoning involved. So you should steer clear of any task that could be **solved with general knowledge or a simple Google search.** If the model doesn’t have to think critically or work through a process, the prompt isn’t challenging enough for this project.

- Second – **avoid prompts with multiple solutions**. If the prompt has multiple correct answers, it won’t be useful for this project.

- Third – **avoid prompts that are too vague.** If your prompt is so open-ended that the model wouldn’t even know what type of output to write – whether it’s a memo, a list of recommendations, or an analysis – then it’s not specific enough. The prompt should always make clear what kind of deliverable is expected. A good prompt should stay focused on **one specific, concrete objective**, just like a real work assignment.

- Fourth – **never plagiarize or use AI to generate your prompt**. The whole point of this work is to have the human experts find the points of failure with AI – so if it’s found you are taking shortcuts, you’ll unfortunately likely be offboarded from the project.

By avoiding these pitfalls, you’ll ensure that your prompts push the model’s reasoning and reflect the kind of expert tasks we want AI to master.

Examples of Prompts

Prompts to Reject	Reason
❌ What is the formula for Enterprise Value?	*Only tests factual recall; does not involve reasoning.*
❌ Name one way to value a company.	*Too many acceptable answers (DCF, Precedent Transactions, Comparable Company Analysis).*
❌ Explain how to do a deal	*Too vague: What kind of deal (M&A, IPO, debt financing)? What industry? What is the strategy?*
Note: These examples are particularly egregious in order to provide clarity. The scenarios you encounter will be more ambiguous, which is why you should flag prompts to your Slack channel.	

Best Practices for Brainstorming Prompts

1. Identify High-Value, High-Difficulty Tasks in Your Profession

Begin by making a list of the complex, time-consuming, or high-stakes tasks that professionals in your field are responsible for—especially the ones you *wish* an AI model could reliably handle but currently cannot. These might include strategic analyses, nuanced recommendations, legal drafting, diagnostic judgments, or context-sensitive communications.

Focus on tasks that:

- Require multi-step reasoning or synthesis
- Involve ambiguity, interpretation, or prioritization
- Are common in your role but remain out of reach for current AI capabilities

This approach helps ensure your prompt targets real-world needs and pushes the model toward expert-level performance.

2. Review the Professional Documents You Routinely Produce

Examine the types of documents you're expected to create in your daily work that AI models currently struggle to generate with accuracy or sophistication. These might be:

- In **finance**: Investment memos comparing potential acquisition targets, or debt refinancing recommendations
- In **consulting**: Market entry strategies that factor in competitive landscape, regulatory risks, and client priorities

- In **medicine**: Clinical notes synthesizing patient history, diagnostic workups, lab results, and proposed treatment plans
- In **law**: Case assessments evaluating precedent, statutory interpretation, and jurisdictional nuances
- In **product management or strategy**: Internal presentations weighing tradeoffs between roadmap options

Please note: this is not a comprehensive list but merely a starting point to help you brainstorm the types of professional documents that may help as a starting point for developing strong prompts.